



MODULE 8

Parents as Partners

How do you make parents a strength for the team — instead of a threat?

CORE THEORY

Parents are the most studied external factor in youth sport (Côté, 1999; Wuerth et al., 2004). Their impact is not neutral: too little involvement correlates with early dropout, but excessive pressure correlates with anxiety, burnout, and sport abandonment. Bloom's Expertise Phase (1985) shows that successful athletes had parents who consciously stepped back during the specialization phase. Coaches who actively inform, involve, and set boundaries with parents demonstrably perform better.

Source: Côté (1999) · Wuerth, Lee & Alfermann (2004) · Bloom (1985) · Ginsburg et al. (2014)

"The best sports parent says nothing to their child after a game except: 'I loved watching you play.'"

— Dr. John O'Sullivan

"Parents who try to make their child perfect steal the child's chance to discover that themselves."

— Tim Elmore

SELF-REFLECTION

- 1 Which parent on your team most frequently causes tension? Have you had an honest conversation about what you expect from them?
- 2 How do you communicate with parents? What do they know about your philosophy and approach?
- 3 When have you needed to set a boundary with a parent? How did you handle it?
- 4 Are there parents who undermine your relationship with specific players? What do you do about that?
- 5 How do you positively involve parents with the team — without letting them take it over?

NOTES

**BOOKS**

- **Whose Game Is It, Anyway?**

Richard Ginsburg, Stephen Durant & Amy Baltzell

Why: The most complete book on parents in youth sport. Practical, honest, and evidence-based.

- **Changing the Game**

John O'Sullivan

Why: Why youth sport is breaking down — and how coaches and parents can turn it around. Powerful manifesto.

- **How Children Succeed**

Paul Tough

Why: On character, grit, and what children truly need from adults. Rewrites the conversation about success and parental roles.

**VIDEO'S / TED TALKS**

- **What Makes a Nightmare Sports Parent — and What Makes a Great One**

John O'Sullivan (TEDx)

youtube.com/watch?v=VXw0XGOFQvw

The most-watched TEDx talk on youth sport and parents. Share with your parents.

- **Developing Mental Toughness in Young Athletes**

Jim Thompson (Positive Coaching Alliance)

youtube.com/results?search_query=positive+coaching+alliance+parents

How to bring parents into a positive culture.

**PODCASTS**

- **Changing the Game Project Podcast**

Parents in youth sport — the line between support and pressure

changingthegameproject.com/podcast

- **The High Performance Podcast**

The role of parents in shaping elite athletes

thehighperformancepodcast.com

⚡ ACTION THIS WEEK

Write a parent letter this week or hold a 30-minute parent meeting. Explain your philosophy: what you do, what you ask of them, and what you promise them.

My approach to better guide parents this season: